

and a graded evaluation. Almost any skill that you wish to acquire, be it learning about Medieval History or Advanced Calculus, Algorithms or Music Production, is available at the click of a button, for free of cost. John Chambers, CEO of Cisco Systems, said that “...the two great equalizers are education and the Internet”, and today, Universities are combining them both to provide an opportunity to learn to millions across the globe.

The number of websites offering free education have exploded over the last few years, to the point that keeping track of all of them has become near impossible. We have, however tried to segregate them into two categories - those offered by Startups like Coursera, Udacity, Khan Academy and Duolingo, and those offered by Universities under the tag of Open CourseWare. The former are usually more interactive, structured like a regular course spanning 4-8 weeks with instructors grading your assignments. Open CourseWare material often comprises lectures that have been recorded during the course, and have later been made publicly available in the form of videos and assignments. We’ve focussed on the former kind in this chapter, and University-administered courses have been covered in the next chapter.

1 **Coursera** (<http://dgit.in/FTCoursera>)

Easily the most popular repository of online courses, Coursera has expanded massively to become a household name in the education space. Founded by Stanford professors Andrew Ng and Daphne Koller, Coursera is a platform that enables Universities the world over to offer their courses online, connecting them to thousands of students the world over, while simultaneously giving students the ability to learn from some of the best minds in the field. Coursera has possibly the largest selection of courses, spanning Natural Sciences, Computer Science, Engineering, Law, Medicine, Humanities, Music and Film, Finance and Economics. Additionally, courses are offered in many languages, including English, Chinese, Spanish, French and Russian.

Coursera’s claim to fame was how closely they mimicked the structure and experience of taking a real class, online. Courses are divided into several modules, each a week long. There are short tests at the end of each week, and larger assignments (with deadlines!) spread through the course. Taking these tests and submitting the assignments on time is necessary to earn a certificate of completion from the University offering the course. When it comes to grading these assignments, Coursera employs the interesting